Artist Discovery Guide

Profiles of key artists, with their style, influences, essential albums and similar artists to discover next. Part of the Spotify AI Assistant knowledge base.

1. How to use this guide

Each profile includes the artist's origin, main genre, a short description of their sound, essential albums and a list of similar artists. Section 4 contains the **Discovery Ladders**: three-step routes that go from a well-known artist to less obvious recommendations.

> **Recommendation principle used in this project:** a good recommendation explains *why* it fits (shared sound, era, influences, producers or collaborations). The Spotify AI Assistant project uses a "70/30 rule": about 70% of recommendations should be close to the user's taste and about 30% should be a step further away, to help the user discover something new.

2. Rock, indie and alternative

Arctic Monkeys

Origin: Sheffield, England (formed 2002) · **Genre:** Indie rock, garage rock, later lounge/psychedelic rock · **Singer:** Alex Turner

Sound: Sharp guitar riffs and witty, observational lyrics in their early work; heavier, slower riffs on *AM*; and a cinematic, piano-led lounge sound on their later albums.

Essential albums: *Whatever People Say I Am, That's What I'm Not* (2006), *Favourite Worst Nightmare* (2007), *Humbug* (2009, co-produced by Josh Homme of Queens of the Stone Age), *AM* (2013), *Tranquility Base Hotel & Casino* (2018), *The Car* (2022).

Influences: The Strokes, The Libertines, Oasis, Queens of the Stone Age.

Similar artists: The Strokes, The Last Shadow Puppets, Franz Ferdinand, The Libertines, Royal Blood, Queens of the Stone Age.

The Strokes

Origin: New York City, USA (formed 1998) · **Genre:** Indie rock, garage rock revival · **Singer:** Julian Casablancas

Sound: Short, tight songs with interlocking guitars, a cool, slightly distorted voice and a raw production inspired by 1970s New York rock.

Essential albums: *Is This It* (2001), *Room on Fire* (2003), *The New Abnormal* (2020, Grammy for Best Rock Album).

Influences: The Velvet Underground, Television.

Similar artists: Interpol, Yeah Yeah Yeahs, The Libertines, Phoenix, Arctic Monkeys.

Radiohead

Origin: Abingdon, Oxfordshire, England (formed 1985) · **Genre:** Alternative rock, art rock, experimental

Sound: They moved from guitar-based alternative rock to experimental music that mixes electronics, jazz and orchestral arrangements.

Essential albums: *The Bends* (1995), *OK Computer* (1997), *Kid A* (2000), *In Rainbows* (2007, first released online with a "pay what you want" model).

Related project: The Smile (Thom Yorke, Jonny Greenwood and Tom Skinner).

Similar artists: Portishead, Massive Attack, Sigur Rós, early Muse, The Smile.

Coldplay

Origin: London, England (formed 1996 by students of University College London) · **Genre:** Alternative rock, pop rock · **Singer:** Chris Martin

Sound: Melodic piano and guitar, emotional choruses and a big, uplifting sound made for stadiums.

Essential albums: *Parachutes* (2000, includes "Yellow"), *A Rush of Blood to the Head* (2002, "Clocks", "The Scientist"), *X&Y* (2005, "Fix You"), *Viva la Vida or Death and All His Friends* (2008).

Similar artists: Keane, Snow Patrol, Travis, The Killers.

The Killers

Origin: Las Vegas, USA (formed 2001) · **Genre:** Alternative rock, new wave revival

Sound: 1980s-style synthesizers, dramatic vocals and big anthemic choruses.

Essential albums: *Hot Fuss* (2004, includes "Mr. Brightside"), *Sam's Town* (2006).

Similar artists: Franz Ferdinand, Bloc Party, Kings of Leon, Arctic Monkeys.

Tame Impala

Origin: Perth, Australia (project started in 2007) · **Genre:** Psychedelic rock, psychedelic pop · **Main creator:** Kevin Parker, who writes, records and produces the studio albums himself.

Sound: Dreamy, phased guitars and synthesizers. Over time the project moved from 1960s-style psychedelic rock towards disco and pop.

Essential albums: *Innerspeaker* (2010), *Lonerism* (2012), *Currents* (2015, includes "The Less I Know the Better"), *The Slow Rush* (2020).

Similar artists: MGMT, Pond, Unknown Mortal Orchestra, Glass Animals, Khruangbin.

Fleetwood Mac and Queen (classic rock)

Fleetwood Mac (formed in London, 1967): their soft-rock album *Rumours* (1977), with Stevie Nicks and Lindsey Buckingham, includes "Dreams" and "Go Your Own Way". **Similar:** Eagles, Stevie Nicks (solo), HAIM.

Queen (formed in London, 1970): theatrical rock led by Freddie Mercury. *A Night at the Opera* (1975) includes "Bohemian Rhapsody". **Similar:** David Bowie, Elton John, Led Zeppelin, Muse.

3. Pop, R&B, hip-hop, electronic, Latin and instrumental

Daft Punk

Origin: Paris, France (1993–2021) · **Members:** Thomas Bangalter and Guy-Manuel de Homem-Christo · **Genre:** French house, electronic, disco

Sound: Filtered house beats, robotic vocoder voices and a love of disco and funk.

Essential albums: *Homework* (1997, "Around the World"), *Discovery* (2001, "One More Time"), *Random Access Memories* (2013, "Get Lucky", Grammy for Album of the Year).

Similar artists: Justice, Air, Cassius, Kavinsky, The Chemical Brothers.

The Weeknd

Origin: Toronto, Canada · **Real name:** Abel Tesfaye · **Genre:** Alternative R&B, synth-pop

Sound: A high falsetto voice over dark, atmospheric production, later mixed with 1980s synth-pop.

Essential releases: *House of Balloons* (2011 mixtape), *Beauty Behind the Madness* (2015), *Starboy* (2016, with Daft Punk on the title track), *After Hours* (2020, "Blinding Lights"), *Dawn FM* (2022).

Similar artists: Frank Ocean, Miguel, Dua Lipa, Daft Punk.

Frank Ocean and SZA (alternative R&B)

Frank Ocean (former member of the Odd Future collective): *channel ORANGE* (2012) and *Blonde* (2016). Intimate songs, minimal production. **Similar:** Daniel Caesar, Steve Lacy, Tyler, the Creator.

SZA (signed to Top Dawg Entertainment): *Ctrl* (2017) and *SOS* (2022, "Kill Bill"). Honest lyrics about relationships mixing R&B, pop and hip-hop. **Similar:** Summer Walker, Jhené Aiko, Frank Ocean.

Kendrick Lamar

Origin: Compton, California, USA · **Genre:** Hip-hop, conscious rap

Sound: Complex storytelling, changing vocal styles and production that draws on jazz, funk and soul.

Essential albums: *good kid, m.A.A.d city* (2012), *To Pimp a Butterfly* (2015), *DAMN.* (2017, "HUMBLE."; awarded the 2018 Pulitzer Prize for Music, the first winner outside classical and jazz), *Mr. Morale & the Big Steppers* (2022), *GNX* (2024).

Similar artists: J. Cole, SZA, Vince Staples, Isaiah Rashad, Anderson .Paak.

Billie Eilish and Dua Lipa (pop)

Billie Eilish (Los Angeles): dark, whispered pop made with her brother Finneas. *When We All Fall Asleep, Where Do We Go?* (2019, "bad guy"), *Happier Than Ever* (2021), *Hit Me Hard and Soft* (2024). **Similar:** Lorde, Clairo, Olivia Rodrigo, Lana Del Rey.

Dua Lipa (London): disco-influenced dance-pop. *Future Nostalgia* (2020, "Don't Start Now", "Levitating"), *Radical Optimism* (2024). **Similar:** Kylie Minogue, Doja Cat, The Weeknd.

Rosalía and Bad Bunny (Latin)

Rosalía (Sant Esteve Sesrovires, Barcelona): trained in flamenco. *El mal querer* (2018) mixed flamenco with pop and R&B; *Motomami* (2022) won the Latin Grammy for Album of the Year. **Similar:** C. Tangana, Bad Gyal, Arca.

Bad Bunny (Puerto Rico): reggaeton and Latin trap. *X 100pre* (2018), *YHLQMDLG* (2020), *Un Verano Sin Ti* (2022, the first all-Spanish-language album nominated for the Grammy for Album of the Year), *Debí Tirar Más Fotos* (2025). **Similar:** J Balvin, Rauw Alejandro, Karol G, Myke Towers.

Miles Davis and Ludovico Einaudi (jazz and instrumental)

Miles Davis (USA, 1926–1991): trumpeter who led several jazz revolutions. *Kind of Blue* (1959) and *Bitches Brew* (1970). **Similar:** John Coltrane, Bill Evans, Herbie Hancock.

Ludovico Einaudi (Turin, Italy, born 1955): minimalist piano composer. *Le Onde* (1996), *Una Mattina* (2004, "Nuvole Bianche"). **Similar:** Max Richter, Nils Frahm, Ólafur Arnalds, Yann Tiersen.

4. Discovery Ladders (Spotify AI Assistant project)

A Discovery Ladder is a route designed by the Spotify AI Assistant project team. It starts from a popular artist and goes three steps further, each step a bit less obvious than the one before. These ladders are internal project recommendations, not official Spotify data.

Starting artist	Step 1 (close)	Step 2 (further)	Step 3 (discovery)	Why it works
Arctic Monkeys	The Last Shadow Puppets	Royal Blood	Fontaines D.C.	From Alex Turner's side project, through riff-heavy rock, to modern Irish post-punk.
The Strokes	Interpol	Phoenix	The Voidz	From New York indie, through French indie pop, to Casablancas' experimental band.
Tame Impala	MGMT	Unknown Mortal Orchestra	Khruangbin	Psychedelia that becomes gradually more groovy and instrumental.
Daft Punk	Justice	Kavinsky	Breakbot	French electronic music, from house to synthwave and nu-disco.
Kendrick Lamar	J. Cole	Anderson .Paak	Noname	From mainstream storytelling, through soul-funk, to poetic jazz rap.
Billie Eilish	Lorde	Clairo	Phoebe Bridgers	From dark pop to intimate bedroom pop and indie folk.
Rosalía	C. Tangana	Bad Gyal	Arca	Spanish fusion that becomes more urban and more experimental.
Ludovico Einaudi	Max Richter	Nils Frahm	Ólafur Arnalds	Neoclassical piano that adds more electronic textures at each step.